

ALISAGAR PARDAWALA

I am the hard disk, one of the most hardworking components of your PC, keeper of the operating system, hardware and software drivers and games, providing you with whatever you need, whenever you ask for it. But lately my performance has dropped considerably, and I know you've been wondering what on earth is wrong. Well, let me tell you the reason for my errant behaviour.

When I was new, all the data I stored was in one place, so I could serve it up quickly when you asked for it. But as time passed and more and more data accumulated, I saved new programs on different clusters, which

are quite far away from each other. So when you ask for the same data now, it takes me more time to furnish it.

Also, all the software you keep loading and deleting makes me a very messy place. There's data scattered all over, and it could be hiding viruses that can crash your system and make life difficult for you in front of the beige (unless you have a Mac) box. So, time for a spot of cleaning.

#### Do it the right way

I've seen that panicky look on your face every time you read the message that your disk has run out of space. But please don't rush to use some free system utility you got on the Net. There are many inadequately tested products floating around that have been developed by non-professionals.

They blindly delete folders from the system that might contain vital data, so you get your 100 MB of free space at the cost of data being lost. This is not the best way to clean me! I would prefer if you installed a cleaning tool like Norton CleanSweep, which can be run once in two-three days to free up space.

These programs are safe to use since they offer you complete control, letting you decide what to keep and what to delete.

I need a minimum 100 MB of free space at all times, irrespective of my size. It would be best if you get into the habit of deleting unnecessary files and folders from the system on a weekly basis.

Some files that I could usually do without are temporary Internet files, cookies and folders and

files in the Temp folder that you have no more use for.

#### Better safe than sorry

While you're on a cleaning spree, you will invariably come across some files with strange names that will stump you. To delete, or not to delete, that is the question. It's possible that these files are vital for the running of some program, operating system or hardware drivers, and removing them might lead to the program malfunctioning or even crashing. The safe way out is to make a backup of the files on a floppy or Zip diskette before deleting them.

Once you're done, restart the computer and check if all the programs are working like they were earlier. If everything is running fine, the files were obviously useless. If any application creates problems, you will see an error message telling you which file is missing. Just reload that particular file.

Do remember that whenever you press the Delete button, you are not really eliminating that

### Cleaning Tools Available

#### System Tools (in Windows)

Disk Defragmenter  
ScanDisk

#### System Utilities (freeware and shareware)

Disk Optimiser  
CleanDisk Pro  
Space Odyssey  
TidyDisk  
ReprMan

#### Dedicated Utilities

Norton SystemWorks  
McAfee  
OnTrack System Suite

I'm your hard disk, and I'm here with a simple yet important message. Listen up buddy, because I'll only say this once,

Clean me Now!

